Sara Court

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EDUCATION

The Ohio State University **Aug 2020 – Present**
Ph.D. Linguistics *Columbus, OH*
Dissertation: Responsible Applications of LLMs in Low-Resource Domains Expected graduation: Aug 2027
Advisor: Micha Elsner

The Ohio State University **Aug 2025**
M.A. Linguistics *Columbus, OH*

University of Florida **Aug 2013**
B.A. Linguistics with Mathematics minor, Summa Cum Laude *Gainesville, FL*
Honors Thesis: Bilingual Processing of Number Agreement in English, Spanish, and Arabic

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Ph.D. Candidate and Research Scientist **Aug 2020 – Present**
Department of Linguistics, The Ohio State University *Columbus, OH*

- Dissertation: develop and evaluate an open-source RAG pipeline that augments LLM outputs with community-sourced materials and linguistically informed databases, letting speaker communities define their own language standards and deploy systems independently of major AI providers
- Collaborate with Community Refugee & Immigration Services (CRIS) to evaluate LLM performance in emergency response contexts, assessing suitability and failure modes for at-risk populations; resulted in a paper in Findings of ACL 2026 and an invited talk at the University of Tsukuba
- Lead a team of five researchers exploring active learning and human-in-the-loop workflows for automated data annotation and analysis, resulting in peer-reviewed publications and an invited talk at the University of Helsinki
- Develop Transformer-based AI models of morphological inflection, contributing to NSF-funded ($330k+) research on the role of analogy in the mental lexicon
- Designed curriculum, implemented web interface, and taught statistics for CogSciDIY, a semester-long language science outreach program for approximately 50 high school students in Columbus, OH and New York, NY
- Publish and present research at peer-reviewed venues in computational linguistics and NLP (ACL; EMNLP; COLM; SCiL; COLING), language documentation (LD&A), and morphology (IMM; MMM)

NLP Research Intern **May 2023 – Aug 2024**
Speech Technology and Research (STAR) Lab, SRI International *Menlo Park, CA*
May 2024 – Aug 2024

- Designed and built an end-to-end evaluation and error-tracking framework for a multi-stage, multi-modal speech translation pipeline for systematic failure mode analysis; produced client-facing reports and visualizations
- Evaluated multilingual OCR fine-tuning experiments across languages and conditions to improve multilingual support

May 2023 – Aug 2023

- Developed and analyzed Transformer models for Mandarin–English machine translation and English ASR
- Translated and curated a custom in-house test dataset (~900 items) for Mandarin–English machine translation
- Initiated and drafted onboarding documentation to assist future hires with technical setup and lab best practices

Research Assistant **Mar 2020 – Aug 2020**
Department of Linguistics, National Taiwan University *Taipei, Taiwan*

- Led group discussions in Mandarin Chinese on NLP concepts as part of the lab's continued learning initiatives
- Co-authored COLING 2020 publication on computational methods for Mandarin morphological analysis

Research Fellow **Oct 2013 – Dec 2013**

Innovative Networking in Infrastructure for Endangered Languages (INNET) *Cologne & Nijmegen*

Hosted by the University of Cologne & The Language Archive (TLA) at the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics

- Awarded one of two government fellowships funded by CLARIN ERIC and the European Commission to help build collaborative digital infrastructure for language research, documentation, analysis, and multimedia archives
- Participated in the INNET workshop for regional archivists on server virtualization, language archiving software, and the CLARIN European infrastructure project for language resources

Research Assistant **Aug 2011 – Aug 2013**

Department of Linguistics, University of Florida *Gainesville, FL*

- Developed stimuli, conducted experiments, and analyzed results of eye-tracking and self-paced reading tasks
- Completed a self-directed honors thesis on the effects of multilingualism on plural agreement in English

PUBLICATIONS

- Dongxu Wu, **Sara Court**, and Micha Elsner. 2026. Are These Programmers Ripe Enough to Eat? Evaluating How LLMs Handle Lexical Knowledge Conflicts in Translation. *Under review.*
- Micha Elsner, **Sara Court**, Galey Modan, Emily Sagasser, and Lauren Squires. 2026. The Virtue of Critical Thinking: Popular Science Discourses of "Your Brain on AI." *Under review.*
- **Sara Court**, Lara Downing, and Micha Elsner. 2026. LLMs in the Real World: Evaluating "AI" in Emergency Contexts. In *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: ACL 2026*, pages 35748–35760. San Diego, California. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- **Sara Court** and Micha Elsner. 2024. Shortcomings of LLMs for Low-Resource Translation: Retrieval and Understanding are Both the Problem. In *Proceedings of the Ninth Conference on Machine Translation (WMT24)*, pages 1332–1354. Miami, Florida. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- **Sara Court**, Andrea D. Sims, and Micha Elsner. 2023. Analogy in Contact: Modeling Maltese Plural Inflection. In *Proceedings of the Society for Computation in Linguistics*, Vol. 6, pages 35–46. Amherst, Massachusetts.
- Micha Elsner and **Sara Court**. 2022. OSU at SigMorphon 2022: Analogical Inflection With Rule Features. In *Proceedings of the 19th SIGMORPHON Workshop on Computational Research in Phonetics, Phonology, and Morphology*, pages 220–225. Seattle, Washington. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- Maria Copot, **Sara Court**, Noah Diewald, Stephanie Antetomaso, and Micha Elsner. 2022. A Word-and-Paradigm Workflow for Fieldwork Annotation. In *Proceedings of the Fifth Workshop on the Use of Computational Methods in the Study of Endangered Languages*, pages 159–169. Dublin, Ireland. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- Yu-Hsiang Tseng, Shu-Kai Hsieh, Pei-Yi Chen, and **Sara Court**. 2020. Computational Modeling of Affixoid Behavior in Chinese Morphology. In *Proceedings of the 28th International Conference on Computational Linguistics*, pages 2879–2888. Barcelona, Spain (Online). International Committee on Computational Linguistics.

INVITED TALKS

- "Responsible Applications of LLMs for Low-Resource Languages." *Linguistics & Generative AI: Ethical and Social Perspectives Workshop*, University of Tsukuba, Japan. Mar 2026.
- "LLMs in the Real World: Evaluating 'AI' in Emergency Contexts." *AI & Ethics Workshop*, University of Tsukuba, Japan. Feb 2026.
- "Responsible Applications of LLMs for Low-Resource Translation." University of Malta, Malta. Mar 2025.
- "AI Basics for High Schoolers." *COSI Language Pod*, Center of Science and Industry, Columbus, OH. Feb 2025.
- "Women in AI & Tech." Center for Healthy Families (CFHF), Columbus, OH. May 2024.
- "Rethinking Tools for the Morphosyntactic Analysis of Underdocumented Languages." With Maria Copot. *Language Technology Research Seminar*, University of Helsinki, Finland. May 2023.
- Presentation on advances in language documentation technologies and the INNET project. *Training Workshop for*

Multi-modal Language Documentation, University of Florida, Gainesville, FL. Mar 2014.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- "LLMs in the Real World: Evaluating 'AI' in Emergency Contexts." Court, Downing, and Elsner. *64th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL 2026)*, San Diego, CA. Poster. Jul 2026.
- "When Is Inflection Lexically Conditioned? Towards a Discovery Method and Cross-linguistic Comparison." Elsner, Court, and Sims. *16th International Conference of the Association for Linguistic Typology (ALT 2026)*, Lyon, France. Talk, presented by co-author. Jul 2026.
- "Shortcomings of LLMs for Low-Resource Translation: Retrieval and Understanding Are Both the Problem." Court and Elsner. *1st Workshop on Multilingual and Equitable Language Technologies (MELT) at COLM 2025*, Montreal, Canada. Poster. Oct 2025.
- "Shortcomings of LLMs for Low-Resource Translation: Retrieval and Understanding Are Both the Problem." Court and Elsner. *Ninth Conference on Machine Translation (WMT24) at EMNLP 2024*, Miami, FL. Poster. Nov 2024.
- "A Unified Account of Maltese Nominal Plural Inflection in Contact." Court, Sims, and Elsner. *15th Conference of the International Association of Arabic Dialectology (AIDA 15)*, University of Malta, Malta. Talk. May 2024.
- "Quantifying Factors Shaping the Morphological Integration of Non-Semitic Nouns in Maltese." Court, Elsner, and Sims. *8th International Conference on Maltese Linguistics (GHILM 8)*, University of Bremen, Germany. Talk. Sep 2023.
- "Analogy in Contact: Modeling Maltese Plural Inflection." Court, Sims, and Elsner. *Society for Computation in Linguistics (SCiL 2023)*, Amherst, MA. Poster. Jun 2023.
- "Quantifying Analogy in Contact: Maltese Plural Inflection." Court, Sims, and Elsner. *Buckeye Language Network Symposium*, The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH. Poster. Spring 2023.
- "A Community-Centered Workflow for Morphological Annotation." Court, Copot, Diewald, Antetomaso, and Elsner. *Language Documentation & Archiving (LD&A 2022)*, Berlin, Germany. Talk, presented by co-author. Oct 2022.
- "Quantifying Factors Shaping Analogical Restructuring of the Maltese Nominal System." Court, Elsner, and Sims. Workshop on Analogy in Inflection, *20th International Morphology Meeting (IMM20)*, Budapest, Hungary. Talk. Sep 2022.
- "A Word-and-Paradigm Workflow for Fieldwork Annotation." Copot, Court, Diewald, Antetomaso, and Elsner. *ComputEL-5 at ACL 2022*, Dublin, Ireland. Talk. May 2022.
- "Quantifying Factors Shaping Inflectional Organization in Maltese." Court, Elsner, and Sims. *13th Mediterranean Morphology Meeting (MMM13)*, University of the Aegean, Rhodes, Greece. Talk. May 2022.
- "Computational Modeling of Affixoid Behavior in Chinese Morphology." *28th International Conference on Computational Linguistics (COLING 2020)*, Barcelona, Spain (Online). Talk, presented by co-author. Dec 2020.

TEACHING

Instructor and Course Designer, LING 3803: Ethics of Language Technology **Spring 2027**
Department of Linguistics, The Ohio State University *Columbus, OH*

Instructor and Course Designer, English Literacy and Mathematics **May 2015 – June 2020**
The Princeton Review (now Trinity Scholar) *Taipei, Taiwan*

- Taught preparation courses for American college entrance exams (SAT & TOEFL) and admissions applications
- Developed curriculum and taught a two-week Math Intensive Camp and an ongoing English literacy program

Pronunciation Instructor **June 2015 – Feb 2019**
Teacher Sammy English School *Taipei, Taiwan*

AWARDS & HONORS

- **CCBS Summer Graduate Research Award,** *OSU Center for Cognitive and Brain Sciences* **Summer 2026**
- **AIDA Grant for Young Researchers,** *International Association of Arabic Dialectology* **Fall 2024**
- **FLAS Fellowship, Quechua,** *U.S. Department of Education* **Summer 2022**
- **CoLang Internal Scholarship,** *Institute on Collaborative Language Research (CoLang 2022)* **Summer 2022**
- **Career Development Grant,** *OSU Council of Graduate Students* **Summer 2022**
- **Graduate Research Small Grant,** *OSU College of Arts and Humanities* **Summer 2022**
- **Ilse Lehiste Memorial Fund Graduate Research Award,** *OSU Department of Linguistics* **Summer 2022**
- **Honorable Mention,** *NSF Graduate Research Fellowship Program (GRFP)* **Spring 2022**
- **University Fellowship** (dissertation year, 2025–2026), *OSU Graduate School* **Fall 2020**
- **ENGIE-Axium Fellowship** (first year, 2020–2021), *OSU Graduate School* **Fall 2020**
- **Huayu Enrichment Scholarship,** *Taiwan (R.O.C.) Ministry of Education* **Fall 2016**
- **INNET Project Fellowship,** *CLARIN ERIC & European Commission* **Fall 2013**
- **Award for Academic Excellence, Intermediate Arabic,** *University of Florida* **Spring 2011**

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Machine learning and generative AI:** PyTorch, TensorFlow, Transformers (HuggingFace), LangChain/LangGraph, Chroma, Pydantic
- **Evaluation and AI governance:** LLM benchmarking, failure mode analysis, multi-modal system evaluation, responsible deployment frameworks
- **Data analysis and engineering:** Python 3, Pandas, Matplotlib, Bash/Unix, Git/GitHub, Slurm/SGE, CUDA
- **Front-end development:** Some experience with JavaScript, Vue.js, TensorFlow.js, Django, and SQL

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Freelance Copy Editor and Translator **Aug 2011 – Present**

- Translate from Mandarin Chinese to English and edit English academic and commercial publications in linguistics, healthcare, education, technology, and business
- Deliver web copy, marketing materials, PhD theses, and book manuscripts to clients across multiple stakeholder environments under tight deadlines

Director of Communications **Jan 2014 – May 2015**

Allogy *Orlando, FL & Nairobi, Kenya*

- Led a team of writers and designers to update company websites and draft white papers, conference proposals, grant applications, and multimedia web content

Digital Content Editor **May 2012 – Jan 2014**

Allogy *Orlando, FL & Nairobi, Kenya*

- Collaborated with local partners to format education and healthcare materials using HTML and Allogy's CMS

LEADERSHIP, POLICY & SERVICE

Invited Scientist, Roundtable on Content Moderation in Quechua Communities **Mar 2025**

Center for Democracy & Technology (CDT)

- One of ~20 invited scholars contributing expert input on fairness, accountability, and transparency of AI content moderation for low-resource languages of the Global South, as a Quechua language technology specialist
- Findings informed two published CDT reports (Thakur, 2025; Elswah, Bhatia & Thakur, 2025)

AI Literacy Consultant & Workshop Facilitator **Jan 2024 – Present**
CRIS, CFHF, and CDT *Columbus, OH*

- Design and deliver hands-on workshops on AI basics, digital literacy, privacy, and tech career paths, focused on empowering underrepresented communities in Franklin County
- Develop resources and lead discussions on computer science, digital empowerment, and workforce access to reduce barriers and improve representation in AI, software, data, and technology fields

President **Aug 2023 – Aug 2024**
Student Linguistics Society (SLA), The Ohio State University *Columbus, OH*

- Awarded $1,000 DEIJ grant to implement a "hidden curriculum" mentorship program for incoming graduate students, including workshops on imposter syndrome, mental health, and professionalization
- Established Teams SharePoint to streamline communication and resource sharing; led revisions creating new communication pipelines among linguistics graduate students and faculty

Vice President **Aug 2022 – Aug 2023**
Student Linguistics Society (SLA), The Ohio State University *Columbus, OH*

- Created cloud-based shared teaching materials repository to support GTA instructors of undergraduate courses
- Organized recruitment weekend and prepared welcome materials for incoming first-year students

Organizing Committee Member **Aug 2021**
5th American International Morphology Meeting (AIMM5), The Ohio State University *Columbus, OH (Online)*

Volunteer **Mar 2014**
28th Annual Symposium on Arabic Linguistics, University of Florida *Gainesville, FL*

NATURAL LANGUAGES

- English (native)
- Mandarin Chinese (fluent)
- French (conversational)
- Spanish (conversational)
- Maltese (intermediate)
- Southern Quechua (intermediate)